

This is a postprint version of the following published document:

Riera, P., & Garmendia, A. (2024). The 2023 Spanish general elections and the fourth Sánchez cabinet: A successful gamble for the left? *Mediterranean Politics*, 1–14.

DOI:[10.1080/13629395.2024.2405780](https://doi.org/10.1080/13629395.2024.2405780)

© The author(s)



This work is licensed under a

[Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/).

The 2023 Spanish General Elections and the Fourth Sánchez Cabinet:

A Successful Gamble for the Left?

Pedro Riera (Department of Social Sciences-Juan March Institute, UC3M:
priera@clio.uc3m.es)

Amuitz Garmendia (Department of Social Sciences-Juan March Institute, UC3M)

Abstract

This article examines the July 2023 general elections in Spain and its potential impact on the governance of the country. Contrary to what most pre-election polls predicted, the two main opposition parties (i.e., PP and Vox) did not manage to earn sufficient electoral support and, as a result, a new coalition government of center-left parties was formed. The outcome of these elections was notably shaped by the high levels of polarization registered in the country in the last years. This report tackles the most important elements of the elections with a historical perspective and an empirical approach, and how the subsequent formation of a new left-wing coalition government at the national level could affect the future electoral prospects of the incumbent parties.

On 23 July 2023, the 15th general elections since the beginning of the current democratic period took place in Spain. The incumbent parties were for the first time more than one: The Socialist Party (Partido Socialista Obrero Español [Spanish Socialist Worker Party - PSOE, social democratic]) and Unidas Podemos (United We Can [UP, radical left]). The Socialist Prime Minister, Pedro Sánchez, had called a snap election two months ago after a clear defeat of the national incumbent parties in the May regional and local elections that involved losing the power in 6 out of 9 regions where his party ruled. Calling early elections was a risky bet for Sánchez that quite unexpectedly worked out. On the one hand, the center-left leader sought to take advantage of the backlash generated by the formation of ‘right-to-far-right’ cabinets at the regional level between the Partido Popular (Popular Party – PP, conservative) and Vox (Voice, radical right) in a highly polarized context. On the other hand, the term had been plagued with problems of different kinds: sanitary like the COVID-19 pandemic, economic like the War in Ukraine and the subsequent inflation crisis, and, above all, political like the turbulent negotiations with non-governing and frequently secessionist parties to ensure their support in Parliament. Despite these latter difficulties, the right-wing national opposition parties did not manage to obtain a majority of seats in Parliament after the 2023 general elections and a new centre-left coalition government was formed in November of that year.

Within this context, this report focuses on the potential impact of the 2023 general elections and the subsequent formation of a new left-wing coalition government at the national level on the future political prospects of incumbent parties in Spain. Although in principle the fourth cabinet led by Pedro Sánchez looks very similar than the previous one, the parliamentary situation of the Socialist Prime Minister is more difficult this term because, unlike the previous three years, all

peripheral parties, including the Catalan secessionist and the political heirs of the Basque terrorist group ETA (Euskadi Ta Askatasuna, Basque Country and Freedom), have become veto players in the legislative arena. Since these circumstances turn every vote in the Spanish Parliament into an acid test for the survival of the national government, this article seeks to examine whether this weak situation of the cabinet in the legislature can deteriorate the re-election chances of PSOE and Sumar.

The rest of the report proceeds as follows. The next section provides a brief overview of the rules employed in Spain to elect the lower chamber of the national parliament and the party system in place since the democratic transition. Following that, we provide a detailed account of the most crucial events occurring since the last general elections in November 2019 and delve into the key issues that surfaced during the campaign of the July 2023 general elections. Subsequently, we display and analyze the outcomes of these elections focusing on the performance of the four main state-wide parties: the left-wing incumbents (PSOE and Sumar) and the right-wing opposition (PP and Vox). Finally, the report concludes with a discussion of the potential linkage between, on the one hand, the 2023 political developments in Spain and, on the other hand, the future electoral prospects of the national incumbent parties.

1. Electoral rules and party system

Since the founding democratic elections in 1977, Spain has employed a proportional system to elect the 350 members of the lower chamber of the national parliament. In order to achieve this goal, the country is divided into 50 multi-member and 2 single-member electoral districts. Seats are then allocated to closed party lists that have obtained at least 3% of the vote at the district level following the D'Hondt method.¹ The combination of a comparatively low and high-varying district magnitude and the overrepresentation of rural areas has traditionally conferred an advantage to major parties, mostly if they are conservative (Montero and Riera 2009). This has had consequences for the politics of government formation in the country.

Between 1977 and 2015, Spanish democracy had traditionally revolved around two main political forces: The Socialist Party on the center-left, and the Unión de Centro Democrático (Union of Democratic Center - UCD) or Alianza Popular/Partido Popular (Popular Alliance/Popular Party - AP/PP) on the center-right. Since the 1977 democratic transition, these parties had always led the national government, either a majority or a minority one. In fact, until 2020 Spain and Malta were the only democracies in Western Europe without a coalition government at the national level since WW II (Döring et al. 2023). However, the political landscape of the country started to dramatically change after the 2015 general elections, when two new parties (i.e., Podemos [We Can - Ps, radical left] and Ciudadanos [Citizens - Cs, liberal]) obtained parliamentary representation for the first time (Orriols and Cordero 2016). In 2019, a third party, the radical right Vox,

¹ Under the D'Hondt method, each party's total number of votes is sequentially divided by 1 and the series of subsequent natural numbers up to the total number of seats to allocate (i.e., 1, 2, 3, 4, etc.). Each division produces an average, and the list with the 'highest average vote' is awarded the first seat, the next highest the second seat, and so on, until all seats have been allocated.

made its breakthrough into the national parliament. These important transformations of the party system, that had a clear impact on its level of fragmentation, triggered the formation of the first coalition government at the national level between PSOE and Unidas Podemos in 2020. Remarkably, the level of party system fragmentation as proxied by the effective numbers of parties did not come back to its pre-2015 values in 2023 and this generated the opportunity for a new coalition government.²

2. Political context and electoral campaign

The outcome of the July 2023 general elections in Spain cannot be understood without considering the role played by four important events that took place since the November 2019 general elections and the subsequent formation of the first coalition government at the national level in the recent democratic history of Spain. Two of them (i.e., the COVID-19 pandemic and the Russian invasion of Ukraine) were international crises with obvious economic implications (i.e., severe economic downturn and important inflation surge, respectively), whereas the other two had a domestic political nature (i.e., celebration of regional elections and change in the leadership of statewide parties). The goal of this section is to underscore the contribution of each of these elements to the development of the campaign of the July 2023 general election and its outcome.

2.1. International (economic) shocks

Slightly two months after the formation of the PSOE-UP coalition cabinet in early 2020, the COVID-19 pandemic outbreak forced the national executive to declare a general lockdown to fight against the effects of the virus from the sanitary point of view. Almost simultaneously, Sánchez's government also decided to recentralize some of the powers previously devolved to the regions to offer a more coordinated and, hence, efficient response to the pandemic. These measures appeared to work out and Spain slowly started to revert its overall catastrophic numbers of the beginning of the crisis. However, these measures found the radical opposition of some regional PP governments and, above all, the Prime Minister of Madrid Isabel Díaz Ayuso, who advocated less restrictive policies even if they meant higher casualty rates. Within this context, partisan and social tensions developed, turning Spain into the most politically polarized European democracy on questions related to the pandemic.³ Despite this controversy, the programs the national government adopted to limit the economic impact of COVID performed quite successfully and they probably cushioned the drops in popularity of the left-wing national incumbents.

² Figure A1 of the Online Appendix displays the effective numbers of electoral and legislative parties between 1977 and 2023.

³ The Russian invasion of Ukraine and the subsequent inflation surge became the second serious economic problem of the term for the PSOE-UP government. As in the case of COVID, Sánchez's cabinet tried to diminish some of the worst consequences of the crisis by subsidizing sectors that were mostly harmed by it. Although this crisis had obvious economic consequences that could be vividly felt in the months before the 2023 general elections, we are not focusing on the Russian invasion of Ukraine in this report because international politics has not been a major source of internal friction in recent years in Spain and this issue is not an exception in this regard.

2.2.Domestic (political) developments

The main sources of political turbulence in Spain between 2019 and 2023 were domestic. The regional elections that took place during this period had unprecedented consequences for national politics (Garmendia and Riera 2024). Up to three main statewide parties (i.e., Partido Popular, Ciudadanos and Unidas Podemos) changed their national leaders as a direct or indirect consequence of midterm regional elections, provoking as a result that in 2023 Pedro Sánchez (PSOE) and Santiago Abascal (Vox) were the only national leaders who had already run as main candidates in a previous general election.⁴ Above all, the defeat of left-wing parties in the May 2023 regional and local elections led Prime Minister Sánchez to call the snap election of the 23rd of July. Also, the extremely bad result of Ciudadanos on the same occasion provoked the decision of the party of not running in the 2023 general elections. Finally, the May 2023 elections opened the door to the formation of ‘right-to-far-right’ cabinets between PP and Vox, something that left-wing parties would intensely use over the general elections campaign.

2.3.The electoral campaign

The campaign of the July 2023 general elections can be considered as a prolongation of the highly negative campaign that preceded the regional elections of that same year.⁵ The campaigns of the parties of both the right- and the left-wing blocs were particularly designed to highlight the perceived weaknesses of their opponents rather than emphasize their own merits. The highly polarized political landscape provided the perfect context for this kind of negative messages, that were, in turn, increasing even more the level of interparty animosity registered in Spain in the last years. On the right, both PP and Vox campaigned on ending *Sanchismo* or the policies and alliances of the Socialist Prime Minister and his coalition government. Within this context, right-wing supporters popularized the slogan “¡Que te vote Txapote!” (Let Txapote vote for you)⁶ as a way of accusing Sánchez to collude with the political successors of the Basque terrorist group ETA now represented by EH Bildu (Euskal Herria Bildu, Let’s Gather the Basque Country). Policy-wise, the main criticism of the right-wing parties revolved around the 2022 sexual assault law (known as Ley del solo sí es sí [Law of only yes is yes] to highlight the need of explicit mutual consent to engage in sexual activity with a person), which made possible the release of more than 100 convicted sexual offenders. Meanwhile, on the opposite side of the ideological spectrum, both PSOE and Sumar took advantage of the formation of governments between PP and Vox in two regions (i.e., Comunitat Valenciana and Extremadura)⁷ during the campaign to depict the election as a

⁴ Alberto Núñez Feijóo replaced Pablo Casado as leader of the Popular Party in April 2022, whereas Yolanda Díaz and her new party Sumar aimed at taking the place previously occupied by Pablo Iglesias and Unidas Podemos, respectively.

⁵ For a review of the political science literature on negative campaigning, see Lau and Rovner (2009).

⁶ This referred to Francisco Javier García Gaztelu, the ETA member nicknamed “Txapote”.

⁷ Almost simultaneously, a PP politician (Marga Prohens) was invested prime minister in a third region (Illes Balears), making it to a total of four autonomous communities where the conservatives governed with the direct or indirect support of the radical right (in Castilla y León, PP and Vox had been in government together since April 2022). In two additional regions, Aragón and Murcia, PP and Vox only agreed to form a government after the 2023 general elections.

choice between two radically different options. Also, in the last week before the elections Sumar intensified its attacks against the PP candidate, Alberto Núñez Feijóo, by reminding the electorate about his ties with the drug trafficker Marcial Dorado in the 1990s.

Political surveys conducted those days were somewhat reflecting these patterns. According to the June 2023 Barometer of the *Centro de Investigaciones Sociológicas* (Center for Sociological Research, CIS), almost one out of three Spanish citizens considered general political issues like the misbehavior of politicians or the lack of agreements between parties to be the most important problem that existed in the country at the moment. The consideration of politicians and parties as one of the most important problems in the country is corroborated when we dig into political polarization dynamics in Spain. Figure 1 displays the evolution of party system polarization between 1977 and the November 2019 general election (Emanuele and Marino 2023). The graph serves to illustrate how at least ideological polarization has peaked in the last years in Spain. This conclusion also shows up when we resort to public opinion data. Figure 2 displays the evolution of the standard deviation of the electorate's self-placement on the left-right ideological scale since the November 2019 general elections. According to these CIS data, Spaniards are increasingly divided when asked about their ideological stances, suggesting that ideological polarization is a process that at least in Spain happens both at the elites and the mass' levels.⁸

[Figures 1 and 2 about here]

Despite the high polarization, almost all pre-electoral polls predicted that the PP would be the most voted party, a victory that would allow it to form a government with the support of Vox. Only the poll of the public and pro-government CIS projected the Socialist Party as winner of the elections, a result that obviously did not happen at the end. The first candidates' debate, that took place thirteen days before the elections and where only Feijóo and Sánchez as leaders of the two main parties were allowed to participate, cemented the status of the former as frontrunner. Even more importantly, the clear command of the conservative candidate in the polls led him to decline participating in the second campaign debate, just four days prior to the day of the election and where, in contrast, the candidates of the other three main statewide parties were present. Feijóo's refusal to participate in the second debate probably hurt his electoral prospects and provoked that the CIS traditional overestimation of the vote shares of the left-wing parties was smaller this time, allowing Sánchez as a result, as we will see below, to be invested for a new term in office.

3. Results

Before moving to the discussion of the 2023 general elections itself, it is important to shift towards an analytical exploration of the historical evolution of general elections in Spain to date. In order to achieve this goal, we first examine how the level of electoral

⁸ Due to data availability and space constraints, we need to focus on ideological polarization, even though some studies show that affective polarization has also increased (perhaps even more) in recent years in Spain (Torcal 2023).

volatility registered in 2023 fares compared to previous years. As can be seen in the left-hand-side plot of Figure 3, the 2023 elections are the fourth most volatile in recent democratic history in Spain, only lagging behind 1982, 2015 and April 2019. The first two were extraordinary because the whole party system changed as a consequence of them, whereas the unusually high value of the third suggests that from now onwards the Spanish political landscape will be characterized by high levels of electoral change.

[Figure 3 about here]

Moving to turnout rates, the 2023 general elections had with 66.59% the second lowest since 1977, lying only slightly behind the level of participation registered in November 2019 (see right-hand-side plot of Figure 3). These two comparatively low turnout rates in a row fit very well the image of an electorate disenchanted with politics we have depicted above and suggest that at least in the near future the level of political engagement of the Spanish citizenry is predicted to be poor. For sure, this average low rate in 2023 also conceals a considerable heterogeneity across regions and, for example, whereas voters from the two Castillas tended to participate at higher rates than the rest, the citizens in the provinces of the Canary Islands, Galicia and Catalonia registered comparatively lower turnout rates. The cases of the latter two are particularly striking because one of the main candidates was the former Prime Minister of Galicia, whereas Catalan provinces had registered particularly high turnout rates on the verge of the so-called *procés* years until 2023.⁹

On the night of the 23rd of July, two things seemed to be clear. On the one hand, Alberto Núñez Feijóo and the Popular Party had been the most voted political option by the Spanish electorate, beating the Socialist Party by more than 300,000 votes (see the details on Table 1) and increasing its vote share by about 12 percentage points relative to the previous general elections. These remarkable gains were brought by the combination of two facts: the decision of Ciudadanos of not running this time, and the electoral decline of the radical right Vox, which lost more than 500,000 votes compared to November 2019. On the other, the victory looked a little bittersweet since PP and Vox had not managed to earn sufficient electoral support to secure a majority in Parliament. Hence, the electoral outcome gave the opportunity to the incumbent parties to stay in office four more years. However, this possibility appeared everything but certain since keeping power implied reaching agreements with the Catalan secessionist parties and the abovementioned EH Bildu.¹⁰

[Table 1 about here]

⁹ Although counter-intuitively, previous candidates of Alianza Popular and Partido Popular from Galicia (i.e., Manuel Fraga and Mariano Rajoy) had not managed to increase the turnout rates in their region in the past either.

¹⁰ Things for Sánchez became even more complicated six days after the elections when the count of the votes cast in foreign countries assigned to PP an extra seat, forcing him to negotiate an explicit support of the pro-independence party (Junts per Catalunya) in a potential investiture if he wanted to become Prime Minister.

4. Aftermath

The result of general elections in Spain was inconclusive for the third time in 10 years. However, events would unfold differently on this occasion and, unlike 2015 and 2019, a snap election would not be necessary. Spain is a parliamentary democracy where the head of state (the King) commissions a particular politician (the *formateur*) to create a government. Until 2015, choosing who would be this person had been easy in Spain: The King appointed the leader of the largest party as the *formateur*. However, after the collapse of the imperfect two-party system in 2015, this decision became more controversial. In 2023, the King faced a difficult choice since both PP and PSOE claimed victory and, as for the first time in the current democratic period, the right to lead the government formation process.

At the end, the King played safe and nominated Feijóo as *formateur* with the passive acquiescence of the Socialist Party and despite the criticism of some factions within the PP that blamed the conservative politician for going to a *fake* investiture without the required support. Only backed by his own party, Vox and two small regionalist parties, Feijóo's fell short of the necessary majority on the 29th of September and brought the country to the brink of a new general election, the sixth in less than eight years.¹¹ Probably bearing this in mind, the King nominated Pedro Sánchez as the next candidate to attempt the investiture. After several weeks of uncertain negotiations and important concessions to the Catalan secessionist parties that included the promise of an amnesty law that, for example, would allow the former regional Prime Minister Carles Puigdemont to come back to Spain free from any criminal conviction, Pedro Sánchez managed to be invested for a fourth term in office with the support of all parties but PP, Vox and a regionalist party from Navarra, leading a coalition government between PSOE and Sumar this time. In line with Gamson's Law (1961), the distribution of portfolios between these two parties reflected their seat shares in Parliament. Moreover, like in the previous term, it had 22 ministries, constituting the second largest in Spanish recent democratic history again (Rodon 2020).

The first year of the current parliamentary term has been characterized by apparent legislative gridlock, moderately low public opinion volatility and steadily high political polarization. With regard to the former, suffice it to say that the Spanish Parliament has only managed to pass two laws (including the mostly controversial text on the amnesty of Catalan secessionist leaders) and one tiny constitutional reform about handicapped people.¹² In the same time span of the last three parliamentary terms with a new government managing to be sworn into office, six (2019-2023), four (2016-2019) and sixteen (2011-2015) laws were passed. These figures suggest that the legislative productivity in the beginning of this term is lower than in previous terms, mainly if we compare it to the term of the majority government of Mariano Rajoy.

¹¹ According to the Spanish Constitution (art. 99), two months after the first failed investiture vote new elections are called if nobody has obtained the confidence of the Parliament. For an analysis of the institutional and political elements that explain failed investitures in the 2016 cycle, see Simón (2016).

¹² It is also remarkable that in the same time span the government has passed 4 decree-laws, which are adopted in theory when there is "an extraordinary and urgent need" (article 86 of the Constitution), but in practice are often introduced when cabinets have a *short* parliamentary majority (if any).

Second, one year after the 2023 general elections, the prospects of the left-wing incumbent parties are increasingly diverging and, whereas the support of the Socialist Party is not eroding, its junior partner Sumar suffers from a serious and widespread decline after Podemos split from the party and Yolanda Díaz decided to quit as party leader (see Figure 4). According to all polls, these facts would mean the end of the left-wing coalition government at the national level and the formation of a new cabinet led by the PP but with the required support of the radical right party Vox in case of new general elections.

[Figure 4 about here]

In addition, the 2024 European Parliament elections, which took place on the 9th of June, registered the breakthrough of a new right-wing party (Se Acabó la Fiesta [The Party is Over, SALF]), which won 3 seats.¹³ Although it is too early to fully understand the ultimate consequences of this emergence, this new entry could mean two basic things. On the one hand, polarization is not expected to decrease and electoral volatility will primarily occur within ideological blocs in the near future as long as PSOE and above all PP keep depending on radical voters and parties to win elections and form governments, respectively. Although within this context the radical right parties are importantly present in Spanish political institutions, it is also remarkable that their electoral strength is comparatively lower in Spain than other Mediterranean democracies like Italy, France or even Portugal. In either way, ideological polarization keeps being high in 2024, as displayed in Figure 2. On the other hand, the Spanish party system will probably remain in flux in the next years as new political parties such as SALF or others could make their breakthrough into the national arena when new general elections are called.

[Table 1 about here]

5. Conclusions

The July 2023 general elections in Spain ended a turbulent legislative term that had been characterized by the formation of the first coalition government at the national level since the adoption of the current Constitution in 1978. Despite a significant right-leaning shift in territorial power triggered by the regional elections held two months before and the forecasts of the pre-election polls, PP and Vox failed to obtain sufficient votes to reach a parliamentary majority and opened the door to the formation of a new centre-left coalition government. This report has examined the development of the 2023 general election and concludes that the high political polarization present at the time in Spain decisively influenced its outcome because, not only mobilized some disenchanted pro-incumbent supporters that planned to abstain, but also persuaded them to stay within the left-wing camp. Hence, we claim that Sánchez's strategy of holding a snap election in the wake of the formation of PP-Vox regional governments was successful at least in the short run. However, after Vox quit regional governments in July 2024 because of disagreements over migration policy with PP, the Socialist Party will no longer be able to use these governments to win votes and will have to change the focus of its future electoral campaigns. The comparative study of the electoral consequences of the

¹³ The full election results are displayed in Table 1.

formation of ‘right-to-far-right’ governments in the whole Mediterranean/European context both for mainstream right-wing parties that join forces with the radical right and for (left-wing) parties that clearly stand against them constitutes an interesting venue for further research.

Although keeping the power came at the cost of granting important political concessions to Catalan secessionist parties, the performance of the Socialists in the elections celebrated in Spain in the first half of 2024 has been mixed: whereas the party has increased its vote shares in two out of three regional elections,¹⁴ it was clearly beaten by the PP in the European Parliament elections of the 9th of June. In the meantime, Sánchez’s government has started to suffer its first legislative defeats and the amnesty law was eventually passed on the 30th of May after being initially rejected by the Parliament. Moreover, Pedro Sánchez appears to have flirted with the idea of resigning amid alleged offenses of corruption against his wife Begoña Gómez, who has received a court summons for the 5th of July. Only time will tell us whether reaching agreements with EH Bildu and Catalan secessionists in the Parliament takes its electoral toll on the Socialist Party or not and, hence, either the term is a stillborn baby or Sánchez and his allies manage to bounce back. Future work could apply our insights to assess the political implications in other South European democracies like France or Italy of electoral alliances or even governments between social democratic and radical parties.

6. References

Döring, Holger, Alexandra Quaas, Maike Hesse, and Philip Manow (2023). Parliaments and governments database (ParlGov): Information on parties, elections and cabinets in established democracies. Development version.

Garmendia Madariaga, Amuitz and Pedro Riera (2024). “The nationalisation of subnational elections in polarised Spain: The May 2023 regional and local elections”. *South European Society and Politics*, 1-27.

Emanuele, Vincenzo and Bruno Marino (2023). “Dataset of ideological polarization in Western Europe”. Rome: Italian Center for Electoral Studies

Gamson, William A. (1961). “A Theory of Coalition Formation”. *American Sociological Review*, 26: 3, 373-382.

Laakso, Markku and Rein Taagepera (1979). ““Effective” number of parties: A measure with application to West Europe”. *Comparative Political Studies*, 12: 1, 3-27.

Lau, Richard R. and Ivy B. Rovner (2009). “Negative campaigning”. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 12: 285-306.

Montero, José Ramón and Pedro Riera (2009). “Anexo II: Informe sobre la Reforma del Sistema Electoral”, in Francisco Rubio Llorente and Paloma Biglino Campos, eds., *El Informe del Consejo de Estado sobre la Reforma Electoral. Texto del Informe y Debates Académicos*. Madrid: Consejo de Estado y Centro de Estudios Políticos y Constitucionales.

¹⁴ Whereas in Galicia (18/2) the Socialist Party lost 5.57 percentage points, in the Basque Country (21/4) and Catalonia (12/5), its vote share increased by 0.46 and 4.93, respectively.

Orriols, Lluís and Guillermo Cordero (2016). “The breakdown of the Spanish two-party system: The upsurge of Podemos and Ciudadanos in the 2015 General Election”. *South European Society and Politics*, 21: 4, 469-492.

Pedersen, Mogens N. (1979). “The Dynamics of European Party Systems: Changing Patterns of Electoral Volatility”. *European Journal of Political Research*, 7: 1, 1-26.

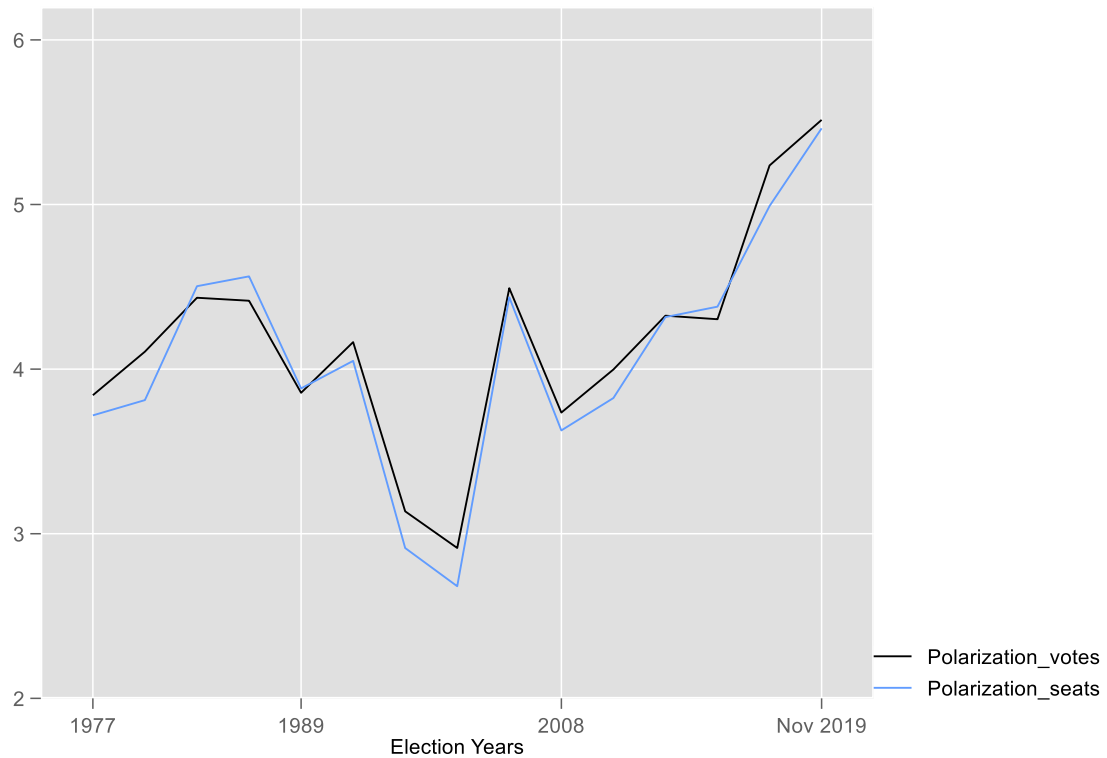
Rodon, Toni (2020). “The Spanish electoral cycle of 2019: A tale of two countries” *West European Politics*, 43: 7, 1490-1512.

Simón, Pablo (2016). “The challenges of the new Spanish multipartism: Government formation failure and the 2016 General Election”. *South European Society and Politics*, 21: 4, 493-517.

Torcal, Mariano (2023). *De votantes a hooligans. La polarización política en España*. Madrid: La Catarata.

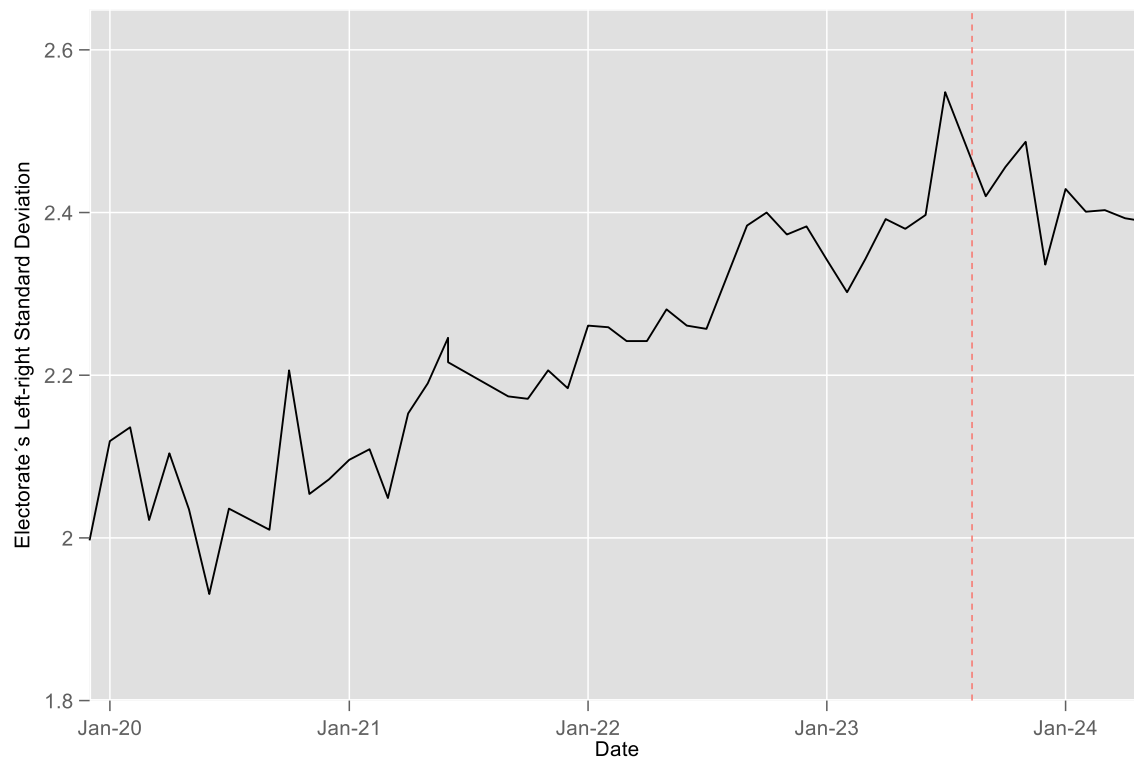
Tables and Figures

Figure 1. Political Polarization at the Electoral and the Legislative Level, Spanish Lower Chamber General Elections 1977-2019



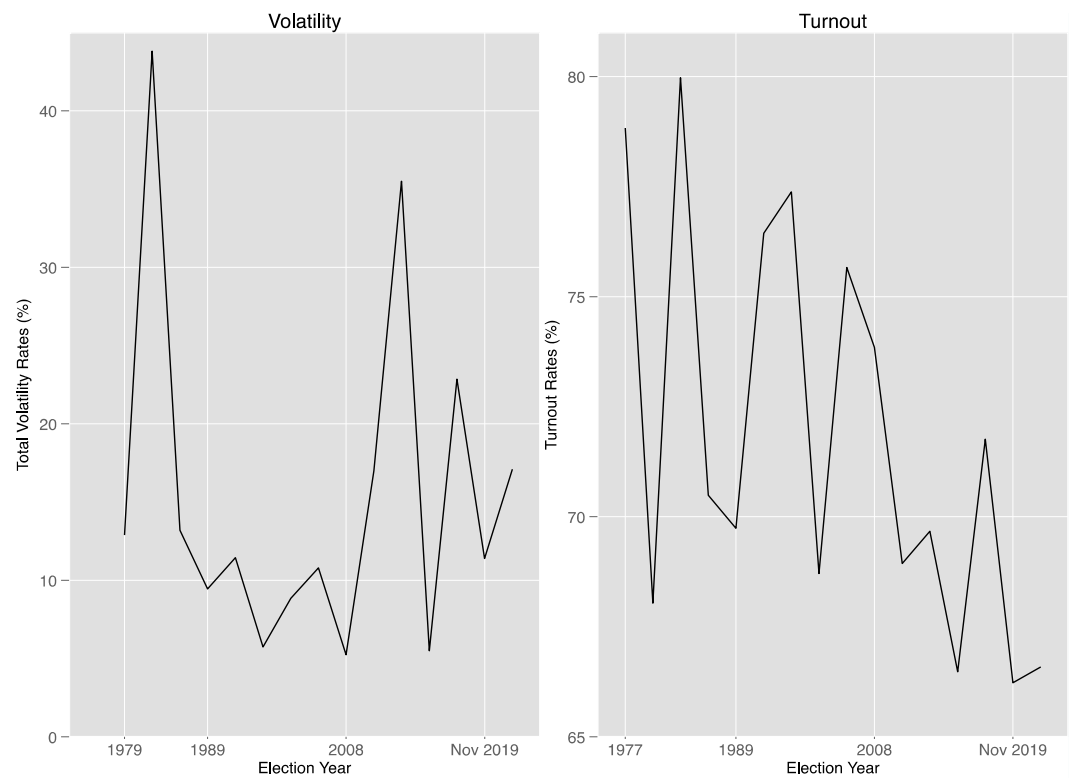
Note: The polarization scores are calculated applying Dalton's (2008) polarization formula to parties' left-right placement according to expert survey data weighted by either vote or seat shares. The scores range from 0 to 10, where higher values mean higher polarization. *Source:* Emanuele and Marino (2023).

Figure 2. Ideological Polarization at the Electorate Level, Spain 2019-2024



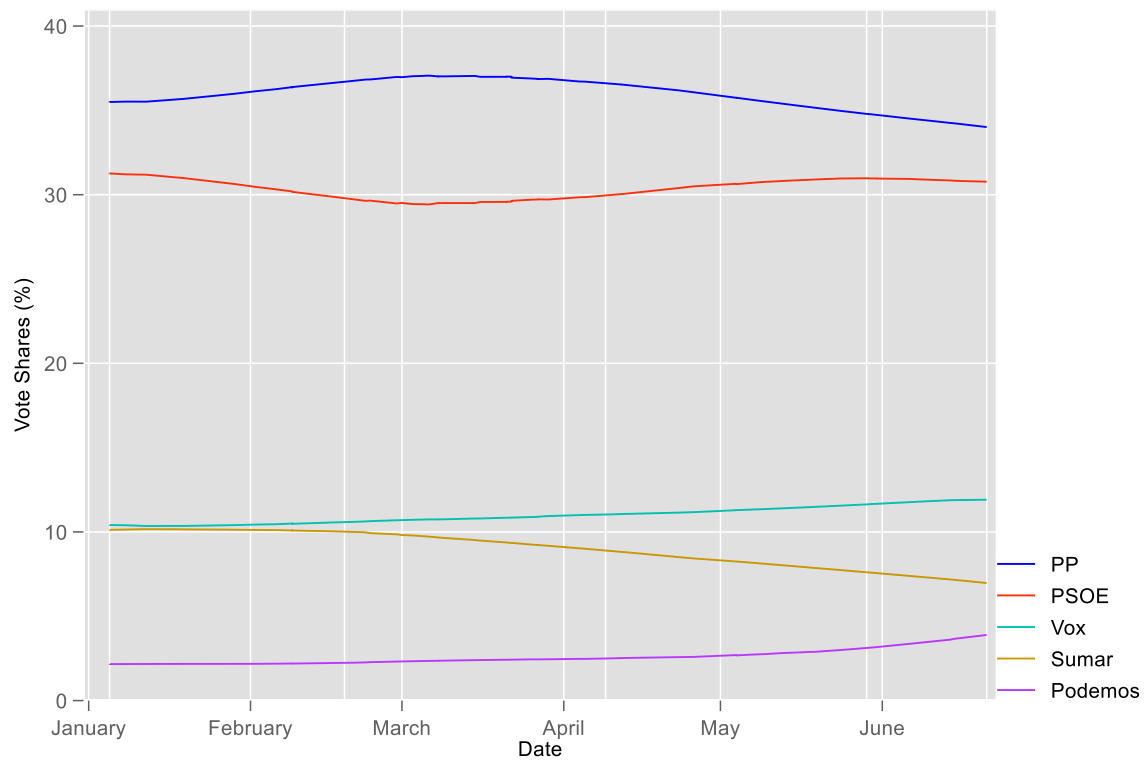
Note: The polarization score is the standard deviation of the citizens' self-placement on the left-right (1-10) scale. The red dashed line indicates the data of the 2023 general elections. *Source:* CIS.

Figure 3. Electoral Volatility and Turnout Rates, Spanish Lower Chamber General Elections 1977-2023



Note: Values of the Pedersen's (1979) Index and number of valid votes over total number of registered voters. *Source:* Emanuele (2015) and Website of the Spanish Ministry of Interior.

Figure 4. Nationwide polling, Spain 1 January-15 June 2024



Note: Nationwide voting intention estimates. For a full list of sources, see Online Appendix.

Table 1. Results, November 2019-2023 General Elections and 2024 European Parliament Elections

Party	E-2024		G-2023		G-2019	
	Votes (%)	MPs	Votes (%)	MPs	Votes (%)	MPs
Partido Popular (PP)	34.21	22	33.06	137	20.81	89
Partido Socialista Obrero Español (PSOE)	30.18	20	31.68	121	28	120
Vox	9.63	6	12.38	33	15.08	52
Sumar	4.66	3	12.33	31	15.39	38
Esquerra Republicana de Catalunya (ERC)	4.91	3	1.89	7	3.61	13
Junts per Catalunya-Junts	2.54	1	1.6	7	2.19	8
Euskal Herria Bildu ^a (EH Bildu)			1.36	6	1.14	5
Partido Nacionalista Vasco (EAJ-PNV)	1.61	1	1.12	5	1.56	6
Bloque Nacionalista Galego ^a (BNG)			0.62	1	0.5	1
Coalición Canaria ^b (CC)			0.47	1	0.51	2
Unión del Pueblo Navarro (UPN)			0.21	1	0.41	2
Ciudadanos-Partido de la Ciudadanía (Cs)	0.69		x	0	6.8	10
Candidatura d'Unitat Popular-Per la Ruptura (CUP)			0.4	0	1.02	2
Partido Regionalista de Cantabria (PRC)			x	0	0.28	1
Teruel Existe	0.23		0.08	0	0.08	1
Se Acabó la Fiesta	4.59	3				
Podemos	3.28	2				
Others	3.47		2.8	0	2.62	0
Total	100	61	100	350	100	350

Note: In November 2019, the vote shares and seats of Sumar are the combination of Unidas Podemos, En Comú Podem, Más País-Equo, En Común, Más Compromís, Más País and Más País-Chunta Aragonesista-Equo; also, UPN is Navarra Suma, which includes PP and Cs, and CC runs with Nueva Canarias. *Source:* Spanish Ministry of Interior. In the 2024 EP elections, EH Bildu and BNG run together with ERC and other smaller regional parties under the label Republics Now, whereas Coalición Canaria runs together with PNV and other smaller regional parties under the label Coalition for a Solidary Europe.